

access. A complicated button layout and menu functions can become a big hindrance especially when you need to quickly shift exposure modes.

### 1.2.9. Optical Vs. Digital Image Stabilisation

If you're planning on shooting for long hours, consider getting a tripod. While shooting from your shoulder may look cool, after ten minutes of holding even a lightweight camcorder, your arms and shoulders could develop an ache. Another important factor that should make you consider a tripod is shakiness. This can happen to a greater or lesser extent depending on how long you're holding the camcorder, and can ruin your video. Most newer camcorders have some degree of image stabilisation.

There are two ways image stabilisation is achieved: digitally and optically. In digital image stabilisation, the camcorder's computer electronically shifts the image in the opposite direction to which the minor shake occurs. Like in digital zoom, the downside to digital stabilisation is that there can be degradation in picture quality.

Optical image stabilisation follows the same concept as digital stabilisation, but achieves it by actually moving the lens assembly to compensate for the shake. Needless to say, optical stabilisation is better than digital, but unfortunately, most consumer-grade camcorders only support digital stabilisation.

### 1.2.10 Widescreen

Widescreen is the ability of the camcorder to shoot in the 16:9 aspect ratio. The aspect ratio describes the ratio of the length to the height of the video. Movies in theatres are usually displayed in widescreen, while TV and video use the 4:3 aspect ratio. The black bars you see when watching some movies on TV is because of the con-

